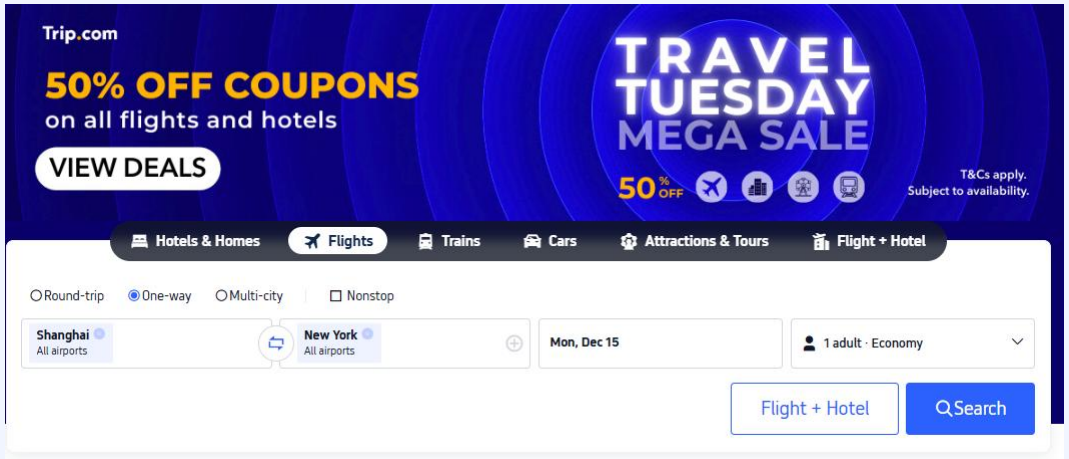
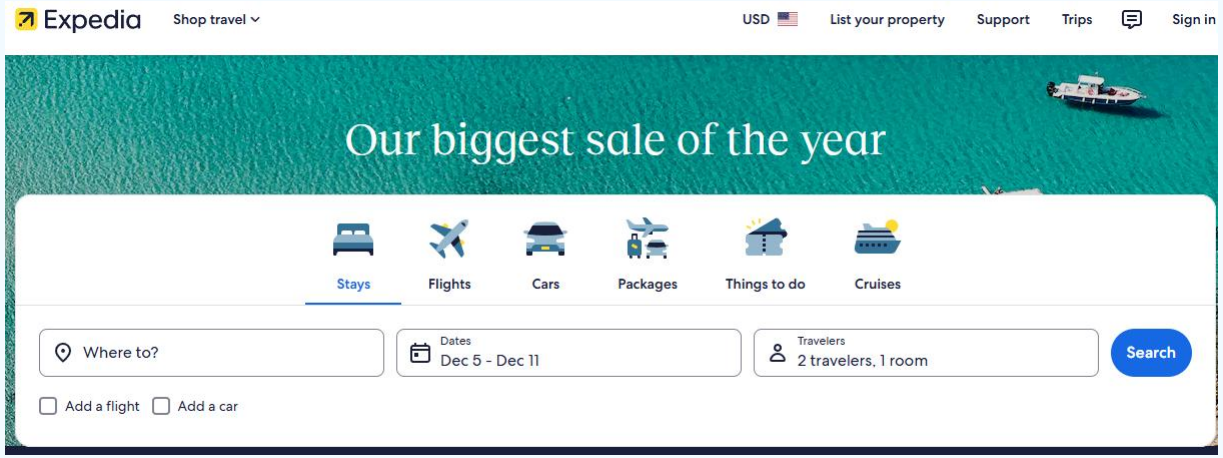
Unlocking the First-Time User: Optimizing Flight Conversion

Trip.com vs. Expedia: A Comparative Deep Dive in Flight Fare Card Page

- **Trip.com**



- **Expedia**



DESK RESEARCH

Foundations for First-Time User Conversion

First-Time User Psychology

Phase 1 — Desk Research

Interstitial Anxiety

Reassure during wait

Clear progress cues. Avoid marketing interstitials.

Cognitive Load

Fewer choices, clear hierarchy

Progressive disclosure; reduce scan effort.

Trust Threshold

Upfront facts over gamification

Total price, baggage, and cancellation first.

- Why first-time users struggle: Three psychological barriers that drive abandonment

Sources:
https://userpilot.com/blog/loading-page-examples/
https://medium.com/@bstanfie/expedia-redesign-f99a765b3811
https://bricxlabs.com/blogs/card-ui-design-examples
https://www.expedia.com/newsroom/transparency-in-travel-pricing-a-win-for-consumers-and-a-standard-at-expedia/

Color Psychology & Visual Hierarchy

VS

Expedia — Trust Anchor Palette

Deep Blue anchors trust; Yellow guides action

Deep Blue
#1E243A • Trust

Vibrant Yellow
#FEBF4F • CTA

Select

Upfront action color creates a clear focal point

Trip.com — Multi-badge Salience

Multiple badge colors increase salience but can dilute CTA focus

Cheapest Trip.Best Member Eco Deal

Cheapest Trip.Best Eco Deal

Select

Competing badge colors draw attention away from the button

- Why colors matter: Expedia’s 2-color system helps focus on “Select”. Trip.com’s many badge colors create competition.

Sources:
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https://medium.com/@bstanfie/expedia-redesign-f99a765b3811
https://bricxlabs.com/blogs/card-ui-design-examples
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Microcopy Strategy: From Jargon to Plain English

Jargon-first

“Economy Light”

“Conditional Refund”

Plain English

“No carry-on bag”

“Free cancellation”

- Impact: Plain language reduces user confusion and increases booking confidence.

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Trust Signal Architecture

What first-time users need to feel safe and proceed

Phase 1 — Desk Research

Upfront Pricing

Total includes taxes & fees

Eliminates late-stage sticker shock.

WCAG 2.1 AA

Contrast + semantic structure

Readable text and screen-reader order.

Baggage Clarity

Calculator integration

Shows carry-on/checked costs before checkout.

Loyalty Framing

OneKeyCash vs Trip Coins

Utility cash value vs rebate gamification.

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Comparison by testing

COMPETITIVE TESTING

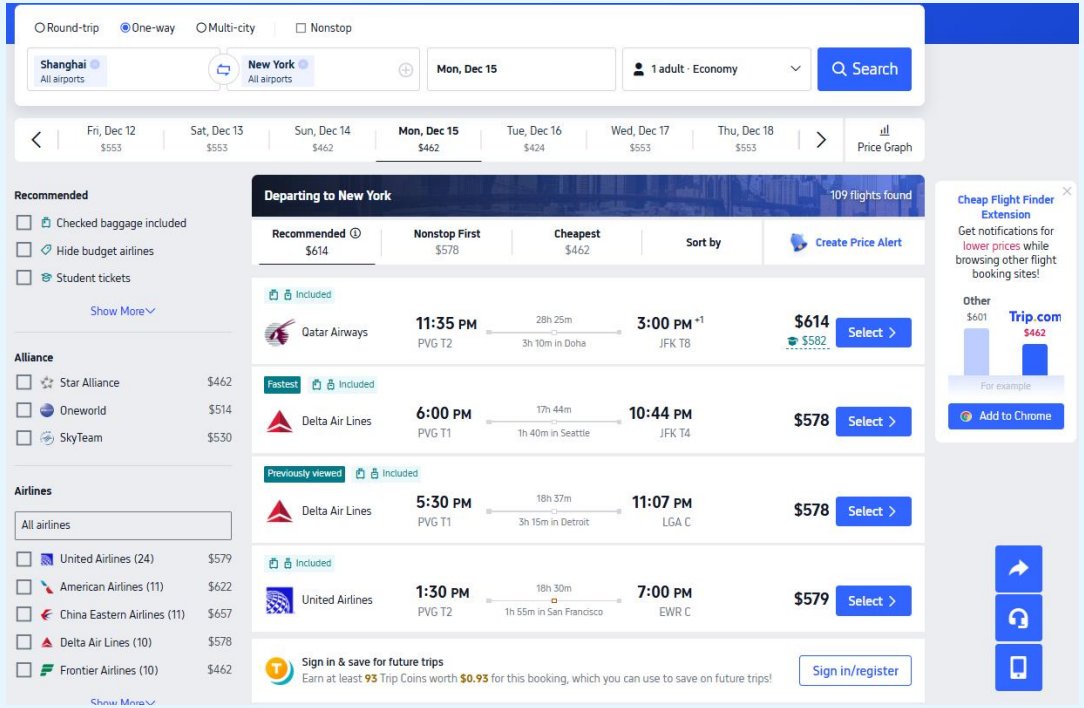
Real-World Usability Analysis: Shanghai→New York Flight Booking

Design Philosophy: Super App vs. Utilitarian

- Trip.com maximizes features and rewards; Expedia prioritizes clarity and simplicity.

Trip.com — Super App

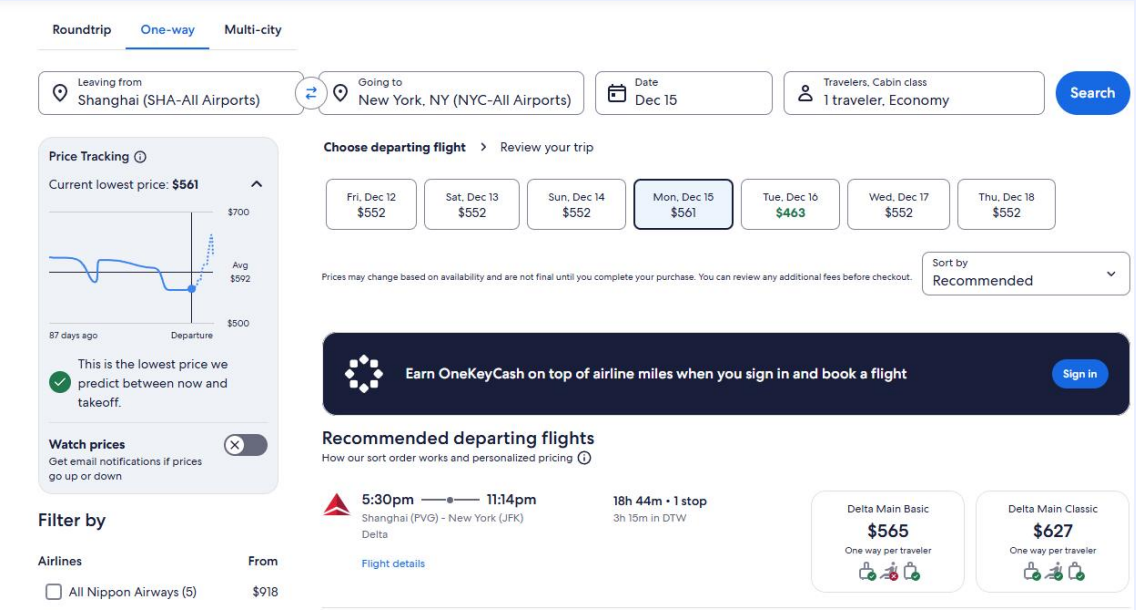
High Density | **Gamified** | **Trip Coins**



VS

Expedia — Utilitarian

Minimalist | **Plain English** | **Upfront Trust**

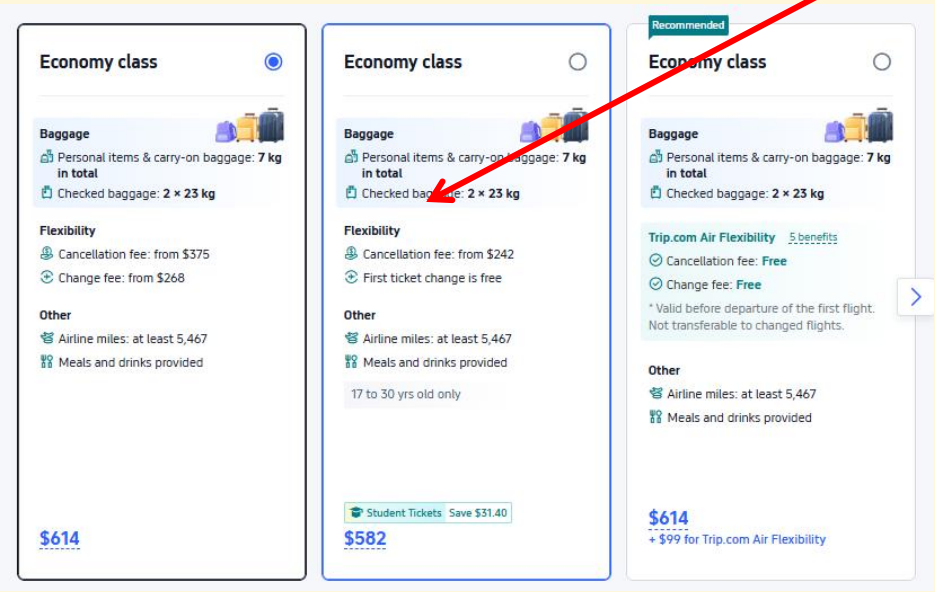


The Fare Family Visibility Gap

- Hidden fare details force extra clicks and increase user frustration

Trip.com

Problem

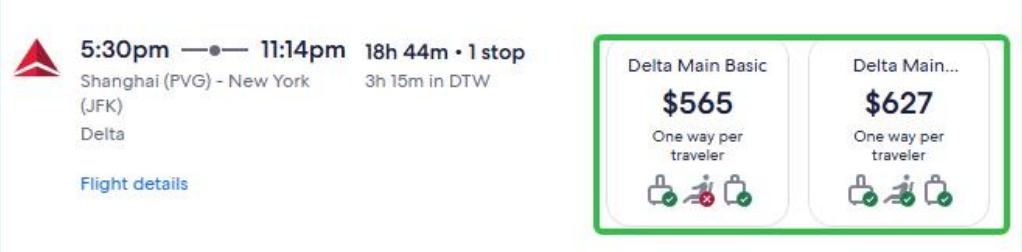


Hidden hierarchy

Baggage rules gated behind a click (modal), delaying choice clarity.

Expedia

Better Practice



Upfront anchoring

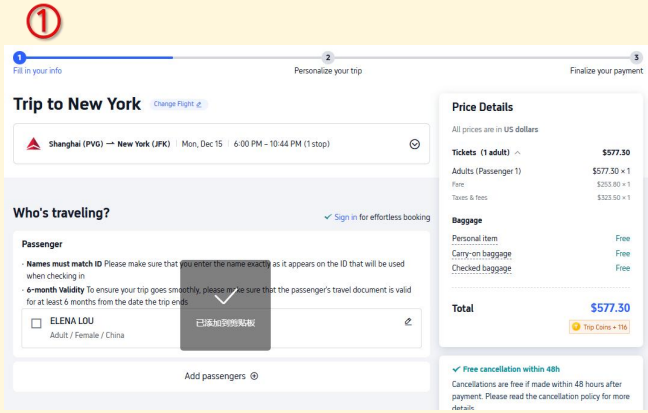
Baggage options visible in list view; trade-offs clear before clicking.

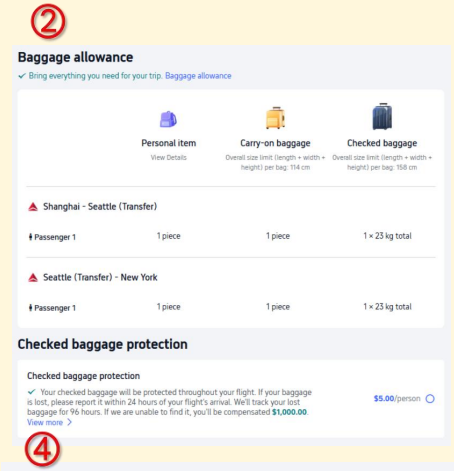
Cognitive Load at Checkout

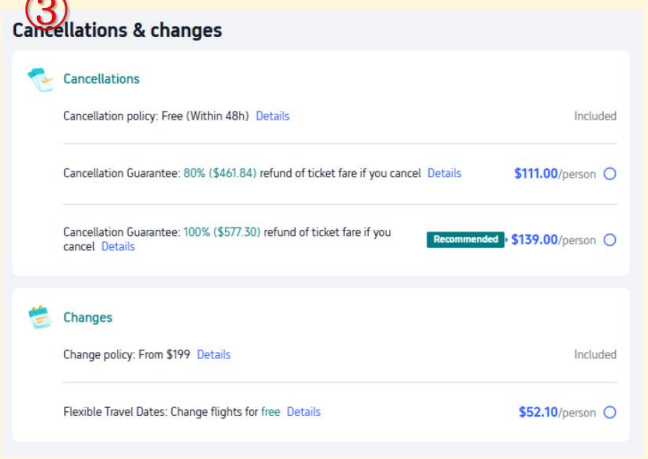
- Cluttered checkout with upsells increases completion time by 42% compared to focused design

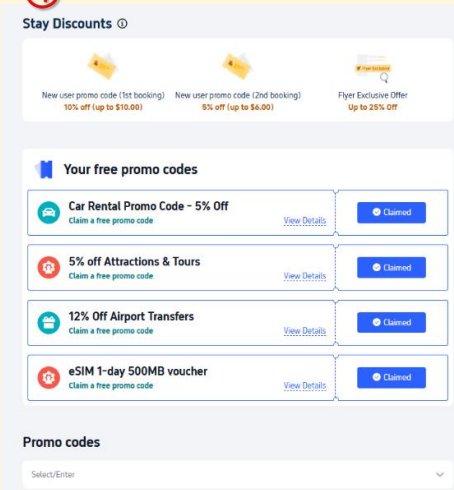
Trip.com — Complex

longer time | Upsell Clutter







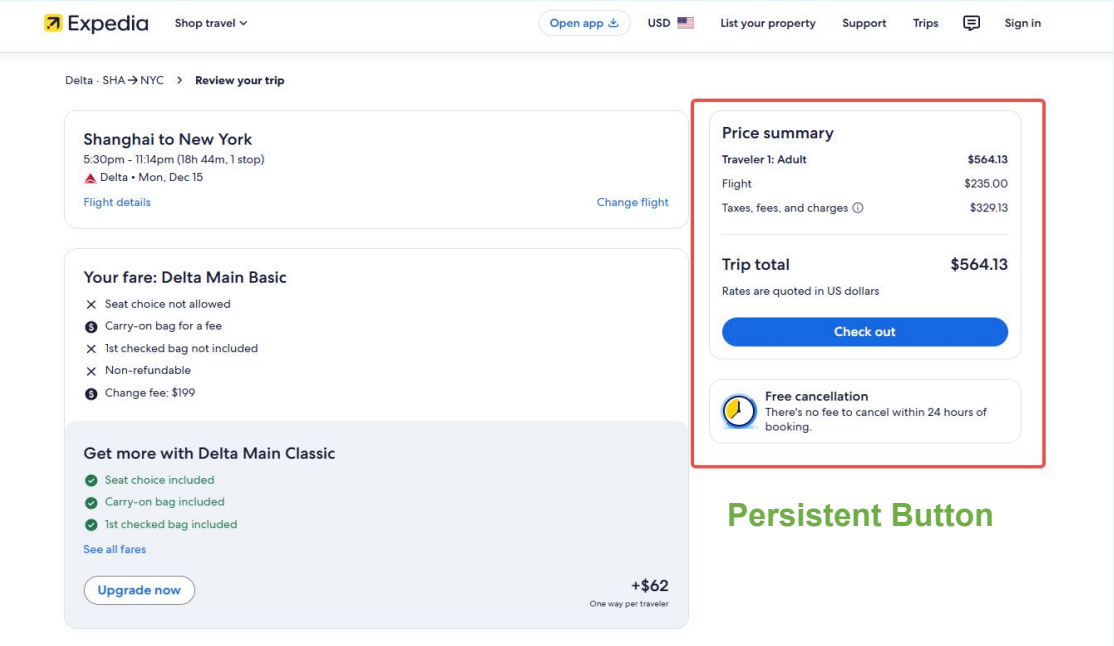


Distraction to payment

Insurance, lounge, and add-ons crowd the critical path.

Expedia — Simple

quicker | Sticky Price Rail



Persistent Button

Focus on completion

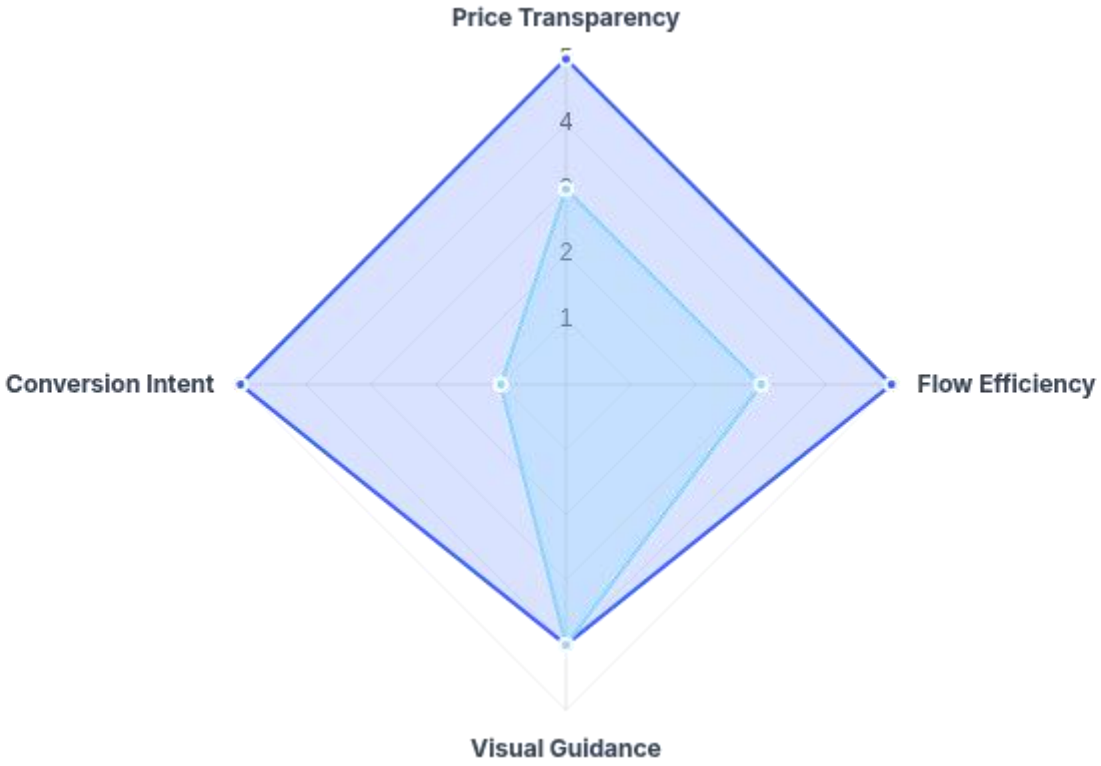
Fixed summary keeps totals and CTA in view.

Benchmarking the Experience

Expedia outperforms Trip.com on transparency and efficiency, while visual guidance remains comparable

Trip.com Expedia

Scale 0–5



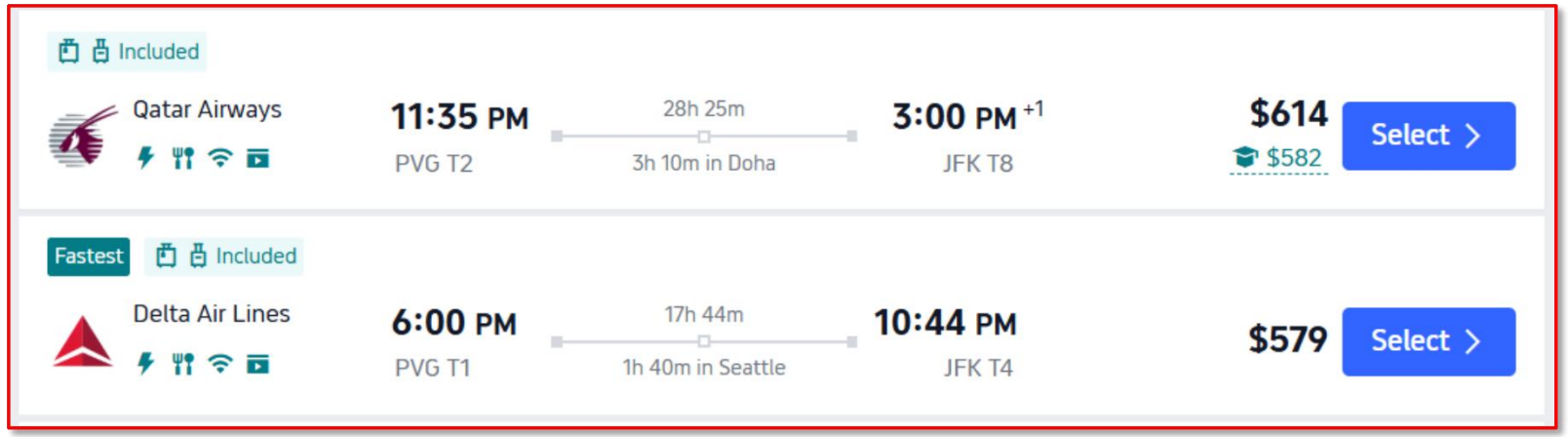
Price Transparency	Flow Efficiency	Visual Guidance	Conversion Intent
Trip 3 / Expedia 5	Trip 3 / Expedia 5	Trip 4 / Expedia 4	Trip 3 (Abandon) / Expedia 5 (Book)

Better Design for Trip.com

Suggested Improvements

Optimization: Surface the Value

Move fare selection from modal to list view to reduce clicks and increase transparency



SHA 08:20 → JFK 19:15

1 stop • 17h 35m

$581.90
Total

Before Fare details hidden in modal

Basic **Standard Economy** **Main** Carry-on included

Designer note: Overlay fare radios directly on the list card.

Increase CTR

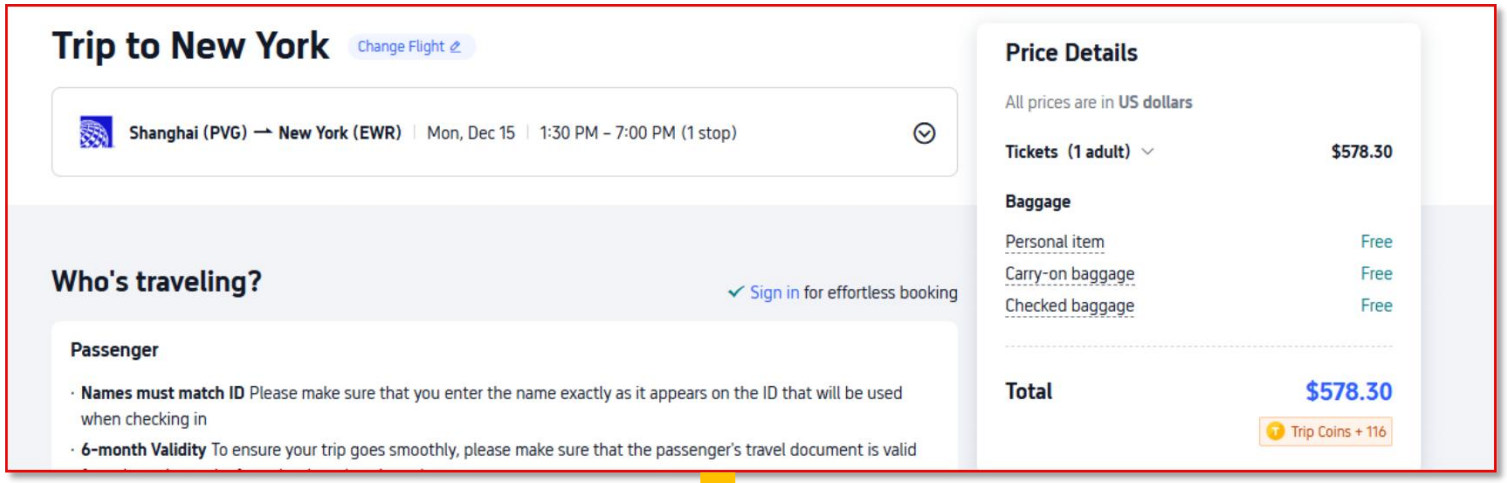
Anchors choice early, reduces second click to reveal baggage rules.

UI Structure

- SERP Card
- Inline Fare Radios
- Baggage Microcopy

De-cluttering the Path to Payment

Two-column checkout with Sticky Price Summary to keep total cost visible and reduce checkout abandonment



Increase Completion Rate

Sticky rail keeps totals and CTA visible through the form.

Checkout Inputs

Form

Upsells and optional add-ons — Partially Crop

Designer note: Crop upsells; overlay a persistent Price Summary rail on the right.

Price Summary

Sticky

Fare (incl. taxes)	$581.90
Baggage	$0
Fees	$0
Total	**$581.90**

Complete Booking

Includes taxes and fees • Plain-English inclusions

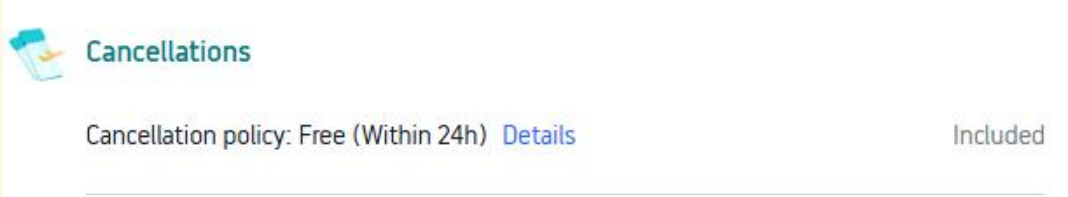
Clearer Language

Trip.com's free cancellation policy not clearly written; Expedia speaks directly to users in natural language.

Trip.com

Problem

Cancellation fee: Free (Within 48h)



Feature: Typical key-value display style not guidance for first-time users.

Expedia

Solution

There's no fee to cancel within 24 hours of booking.

Feature: Conversational tone that clearly explains the rule.

The Hybrid Strategy Roadmap

STEP 1

Upfront Baggage Pricing

CTR ↑

Make baggage costs visible on SERP.

STEP 2

Sticky Rail Checkout

Conversion ↑

Keep totals + CTA fixed while filling forms.

STEP 3

Plain English Review

Content Audit

Replace jargon and unclear expressions with clear inclusions.

- Sequence: 1 → 2 → 3

- Combine Trip.com's engagement with Expedia's clarity.